

## ACT-FOUR - Act Four: The Hanging Office

### Player text

The town thins behind you, fields giving way to forest again. The trees here wear faces, hundreds of them carved into the bark, eyes turned every direction. Somewhere past them lives the person you were sent to find. After everything the road asked of you, the last stretch is the strangest. Whatever is in that crate, you are about to learn why it mattered enough to send a crew to die for it.

### Public objective

Find the Custodian, deliver the package, and learn what comes next.

### Raw source

- Id: ACT-FOUR
- Type: act-divider
- Sectionid: ACT-FOUR
- Sectiontitle: Act Four: The Hanging Office
- Title: Act Four: The Hanging Office
- Shorttitle: Act Four
- Order: 500
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: False
- Caption: The Custodian and the Hanging Office turn the delivery into a choice.
- Mood: table transition
- Gmgoal: Turn the courier job into a calling. The party reaches the person who can receive the package, learns what it really is, and chooses whether to carry the danger forward.
- Publicobjective: Find the Custodian, deliver the package, and learn what comes next.
- Readaloud: The town thins behind you, fields giving way to forest again. The trees here wear faces, hundreds of them carved into the bark, eyes turned every direction. Somewhere past them lives the person you were sent to find. After everything the road asked of you, the last stretch is the strangest. Whatever is in that crate, you are about to learn why it mattered enough to send a crew to die for it.
- Gmnotes: High mercy, high Hush trust, and a safe route make the Custodian warmer and more candid. Low trust, dangerous route, or blood-debt makes the carved faces feel watchful and the Custodian more guarded.
- Playertakeaway: The simple job is over; what you do next is the actual story.
- Storytakeaway: This is where a delivery becomes a reason: the party learns what they carried and why it matters.
- Mechanictakeaway: Act 4 runs on social trust, arcane discovery, and a preparation decision that sets the Act 5 ritual pressure.
- Livetools: none
- Playersafeprojection: ACT-FOUR act-divider Act Four: The Hanging Office The Custodian and the Hanging Office turn the delivery into a choice. table transition Find the Custodian, deliver the package, and learn what comes next. The town thins

behind you, fields giving way to forest again. The trees here wear faces, hundreds of them carved into the bark, eyes turned every direction. Somewhere past them lives the person you were sent to find. After everything the road asked of you, the last stretch is the strangest. Whatever is in that crate, you are about to learn why it mattered enough to send a crew to die for it. ACT-FOUR-carved-trees Carved trees The carved-face trees The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. image-title-caption ACT-FOUR-last-stretch Last stretch The last stretch The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. text-first ACT-FOUR-real-cargo Real cargo What you are...

- Gmscript: Say: "You came to drop off a crate. You are going to leave with a choice."
- Gmreadaloud: The town thins behind you, fields giving way to forest again. The trees here wear faces, hundreds of them carved into the bark. Whatever is in that crate, you are about to learn why it mattered.
- Gmchecklist: Before S04-01, check custodian\_route, package\_status, hush\_trust, ward\_awareness, festival\_boon, strixwolf state, and bramble state. Keep the reveal Custodian-driven. Marlowe may personalize it but never gates it. Before S04-04, say the package, crate, or lion-faced stone. Do not say Keystone Asset in player text before that beat. Keep the deepest ward cost in gmPrivate unless Kyle later confirms a fuller reveal.
- Gmprivate: The Custodian gives the ward truth; the deeper consume/soul-economy truth remains a seed, not an explanation. Locked canon flags: package\_status=lost recovery, Old Sable membership, and the Custodian's full knowledge stance. Athervast is now confirmed as distant world context, not a playable one-shot route.
- Mechanics: presence knowledge instinct hope fear table-spotlight
- References: Act 4 packet sources/Act4\_Upgrade\_Packet/ACT4\_SCENE\_RESEARCH.md Open Questions sources/Act4\_Upgrade\_Packet/ACT4\_OPEN\_QUESTIONS.md
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act4\_Upgrade\_Packet/README.md  
dist/Act4\_Upgrade\_Packet/ACT4\_SCENE\_RESEARCH.md
- Playerbeats: ACT-FOUR-carved-trees Carved trees The carved-face trees The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. image-title-caption ACT-FOUR-last-stretch Last stretch The last stretch The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. The village warmth falls behind. Ahead is the person this was all for. text-first ACT-FOUR-real-cargo Real cargo What you are really carrying Whatever is in the crate is about to become more than cargo. Whatever is in the crate is about to become more than cargo. Whatever is in the crate is about to become more than cargo. text-first
- Gmbeats: ACT-FOUR-carved-trees Carved trees The carved-face trees Say: "The trees here have faces. Not one or two. Hundreds.". The last stretch passes between trees carved with watching faces. The preserve becomes ancient and personal at the edge of the reveal. Tone and attention are mechanics here: let players decide what they study. Players know the approach is strange and watchful. Player takeaway Players know the approach is strange and watchful. "The trees here have faces. Not one or two. Hundreds." "The playable fact is: The last stretch passes between trees carved

with watching faces." Concrete actions for this beat: look closely, ask the Custodian a direct question, commit to a choice, or take one prep action. instinct table-spotlight Story takeaway The preserve becomes ancient and personal at the edge of the reveal. "The trees here have faces. Not one or two. Hundreds." "The story fact in play is: The preserve becomes ancient and personal at the edge of the reveal." This beat changes Act 4 through this exact pressure: The preserve becomes ancient and personal at the edge of the reveal. instinct table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway Tone and attention are mechanics here: let...

- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway The simple job is over; what you do next is the actual story. "Payday is in sight, but so is the reason none of this was ever simple." "You are walking the last stretch to the Custodian. Watch the carved trees, talk it over, and brace for the strange." Give players permission to react before the reveal. Let the table breathe, suspect, and choose posture. presence knowledge instinct table-spotlight Story takeaway This is where a delivery becomes a reason. "You came to drop off a crate. You are going to leave with a choice." "You are about to meet the person this was all for. After that, the job looks different." Do not preview the Keystone reveal here. The useful story fact is that the handoff matters. presence knowledge instinct table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway Act 4 runs on social trust, arcane discovery, and preparation. "No fight here. The moves are conversation, careful looking, and one real decision at the end." "The next rolls are social or arcane, and the prep decision shapes the finale." Carry-in state should change tone, not replace play: trust changes candor, route changes approach cost, prep changes Act 5 pressure. presence knowledge instinct...
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